spot on. Prannoy, an economist by training, had a childlike enthusiasm for numbers. I'd watch him and his 'partner in crime' Dorab Sopariwala, a delightful old-style Mumbai Parsi, scribble away on a sheet of paper, making all kinds of calculations.

Prannoy and Dorab took polling seriously and had developed the concept of Index of Opposition Unity (IOU) as a statistical measure. It had been evolved by looking at the Congress as the principal pole of Indian politics and then determining the potential of victory or defeat based on how united the anti-Congress Opposition was. The IOU method had worked in the 1980s. In the more competitive elections of 2014 where the Congress was no longer unassailable, new formulas were needed. Prannoy and Dorab, in fact, had almost lost faith in poll predictions after the 2004 miscalculation. Even on their programmes, they'd often issue a statutory warning—'Look, you can always get this wrong, it isn't as if any of us have a magic formula.'

It's a warning that my other psephologist friend Yogendra Yadav would also often give. 'This isn't a maths sum, Rajdeep—can we please tell our viewers that.' Yogendra was more academic in his approach—he liked to see himself as a political scientist first, a number cruncher only later. His team at Lokniti in CSDS had evolved a more refined system for a post-poll survey, one with a smaller sample size but which involved going to people's homes with a questionnaire. 'Whether out of fear or bravado, people sometimes can tell a lie outside a polling booth as to who they have voted for—they are less likely to do so in their homes,' was Yogendra's logic. The bigger challenge in any random sampling system remained—how do you convert vote percentages in any poll into seats? That was the statistical jugglery which could trip up a pollster.

Indeed, despite the attempts at a more rigorous exercise of measuring voter behaviour, exit polls faced a severe credibility crisis in the 2014 elections. For some self-styled pollsters, providing numbers to a television channel had become a business opportunity. A sting operation just ahead of the 2014 election campaign had revealed that some pollsters were ready to fudge the numbers if required. A senior politician once told me in all